utilized the close connections with the Left parties in India. Top leaders of the Communist Party of India and Communist Party of India (Marxist) would travel to China for meetings or medical treatment. [10] Both parties were avowedly nationalist when it came to the Boundary Question and other matters of bilateral interest, but the Chinese were aware that they had fundamental concerns about the Indo–US nuclear deal. [11] Knowing the influence that the Left parties wielded in the United Progressive Alliance government of Dr Manmohan Singh, China perhaps played on their fears about India's tilt to the Americans. This may have been the first example of China's foray into domestic politics, but they were careful to remain behind the scenes.

The second dimension of the Chinese strategy was tackling the Americans. Unlike in 1998, this time round, the Americans and the Chinese began on opposite sides. China had felt let down by the Americans in the aftermath of the 1998 Indian nuclear tests, and the feeling had grown that the US was looking at India as a regional counterbalance to China. The Indo–US nuclear deal was seen as further confirmation that these larger geo-strategic considerations were in fact in play. Initially, the Chinese took a studied position of silence vis-à-vis the Bush administration. They felt that the US non-proliferation community, which was still smarting over the fact of India's nuclear tests, would be able to stall any Indo–US deal. The Chinese would, therefore, draw attention to positions taken by the American non-proliferation lobby in order to urge the Bush administration to reconsider the matter.

The mainstream Chinese strategic community also believed that India's wish for strategic autonomy would act as an automatic check on the extent of Indo–US collaboration. Prominent Chinese writings of that period opined that India's goal was in fact to become an independent pole, and India would, therefore, be unwilling to accept any binding conditions